

Plato and Aristotle — MCQ Solutions

Philosophy Optional · Paper I · Western Philosophy

Open only after attempting the corresponding question. Each solution preserves the complete canonical answer, option analysis and examiner trap.

CONTENTS

Page numbers are generated from the final layout. PDF bookmarks include finer subheadings.

MCQ 1. What the theory of Forms is posited to solve	3	MCQ 18. The ten categories	12
MCQ 2. The exact sense of the "separation" of the Forms	3	MCQ 19. Matter and form in hylomorphic analysis	13
MCQ 3. Matching each argument for the Forms to its structure	4	MCQ 20. Prime matter	13
MCQ 4. "Ideas are timeless and spaceless"	5	MCQ 21. The four causes	14
MCQ 5. What counts as substance for Plato	5	MCQ 22. Change, privation and the two kinds of change	14
MCQ 6. The Divided Line	6	MCQ 23. Potentiality and actuality	15
MCQ 7. What separates dianoia from noēsis	6	MCQ 24. The priority of actuality	15
MCQ 8. What the Cave adds to the Line	7	MCQ 25. Remedial drill — what Plato says about the physical world	16
MCQ 9. The Sun analogy	7	MCQ 26. Remedial drill — what Aristotle denies about universals	16
MCQ 10. The participation dilemma	8	MCQ 27. Remedial drill — what potentiality is not	17
MCQ 11. The presuppositions of the Third Man	8	MCQ 28. Remedial drill — how the Unmoved Mover moves	17
MCQ 12. Plato's wider causal resources	9	MCQ 29. Remedial drill — the four causes as explanation, not narrative	18
MCQ 13. Aristotle's critique of separated Forms	9	MCQ 30. Remedial drill — formal cause and Platonic Form	18
MCQ 14. Aristotle's repair of the theory of Forms	10	MCQ 31. Remedial drill — the standing of the "mathematicals"	19
MCQ 15. Substance in the Categories	10	MCQ 32. Remedial drill — citation and verdict discipline	19
MCQ 16. The four candidates for substance in Metaphysics Z.3	11		
MCQ 17. The Categories/Metaphysics question	11		

MCQ 1. What the theory of Forms is posited to solve

Consider the following statements about Plato's motivation for positing Forms (*eidē*).

1. Many sensible things are called by the same predicate, so a single intelligible character must be common to them.
2. Strict knowledge (*epistēmē*) requires an object that does not change, which sensible particulars cannot supply.
3. The theory is introduced principally to explain the efficient production of motion in the sensible world.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 and 3 only
- B. 1 and 2 only
- C. 2 and 3 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: B.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: it pairs the sound one-over-many premise with the one function Forms notoriously fail to discharge, since Aristotle's standing objection at *Metaphysics* I.9 is precisely that separated Forms cannot originate motion. - **B:** Correct: the one-over-many argument (*hen epi pollōn*) and the argument from knowledge are the two load-bearing motivations, running from *Republic* V–VII and reported again at *Parmenides* 132a. - **C:** Incorrect: statement 2 is sound but statement 3 imports an efficient-causal role that the middle dialogues never assign to Forms and that the *Timaeus* hands instead to the Demiurge. - **D:** Incorrect: accepting all three treats an objection against the theory as though it were one of the theory's own purposes.

Examiner trap 1: Writing that Forms were introduced to explain change inverts the doctrine. Forms are introduced to explain stability and intelligibility *despite* change; explaining change is Aristotle's project, not Plato's.

MCQ 2. The exact sense of the "separation" of the Forms

When Plato is said to hold that Forms are separate from sensible particulars, the claim is best understood as meaning that

- A. Forms occupy a second physical location, lying spatially remote from the world our senses reach
- B. Forms are shared concepts assembled in the minds of those who use a common predicate correctly
- C. Forms exist independently of their sensible instances and are non-spatial and non-temporal
- D. Forms are the microscopic constituents out of which sensible particulars are assembled

Answer: C.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: "intelligible realm" is a structural expression, not a geography; a Form has no magnitude, shape or position, so it cannot be somewhere at all. - **B:** Incorrect: this is conceptualism, which Plato rejects — the Form of Beauty would then depend on minds, whereas Plato needs it to be the standard against which minds are corrected. - **C:** Correct: separation is ontological independence plus non-spatiality and non-temporality, which is exactly what the 2025 "timeless and spaceless" demand tests. - **D:** Incorrect: making Forms physical parts revives the participation dilemma of *Parmenides* 131a–c, where a divided Form of Smallness would absurdly make its participants large.

Examiner trap 2: The word "realm" is safe only if you immediately deny that it names a place. Candidates who describe a second world with Forms sitting in it hand the examiner Aristotle's duplication objection ready-made.

MCQ 3. Matching each argument for the Forms to its structure

Match each argument with its distinctive move.

1. One-over-many — 2. Argument from knowledge — 3. Argument from opposites — 4. Recollection (*anamnēsis*)

I. Sensible things are both F and not-F in different relations, whereas the F itself never is. II. We judge sensibles as falling short of a perfection we never met in sense, so the soul must have known it before. III. A common predicate applied to many requires one thing they all share. IV. Knowledge needs a stable object, and sensibles are in flux.

Which of the following is the correct matching?

A. 1–III, 2–IV, 3–I, 4–II

B. 1–IV, 2–III, 3–II, 4–I

C. 1–III, 2–I, 3–IV, 4–II

D. 1–II, 2–IV, 3–I, 4–III

Answer: A.

Option explanations: - **A:** Correct: one-over-many supplies the unity premise, the knowledge argument supplies the stability premise, the opposites argument at *Phaedo* 74a–75d supplies the non-relativity premise, and recollection at *Phaedo* 72e–77a and *Meno* 80d–86c supplies the access premise. - **B:** Incorrect: it swaps the unity and stability premises and misassigns recollection to the relativity of sensibles. - **C:** Incorrect: it makes the argument from knowledge turn on compresence of opposites, which is a distinct argument with a distinct textual home. - **D:** Incorrect: it treats one-over-many as an argument about the pre-natal soul and reduces recollection to a claim about shared predicates.

Examiner trap 3: Recollection is one supporting route to the Forms, not Plato's whole epistemology. Answers that reduce Platonic knowledge to remembering lose the *Republic's* dialectical ascent entirely.

MCQ 4. "Ideas are timeless and spaceless"

The property that most directly explains why Forms can be objects of knowledge rather than of opinion is that they

- A. are more numerous and far more finely differentiated than the sensible things that imitate them
- B. admit no generation or alteration and occupy no position, being self-identically what they are
- C. are perceived by an inner sense which operates on much the same principles as ordinary sight
- D. change far more slowly than sensible particulars and therefore approximate stability more closely

Answer: B.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: number and differentiation are irrelevant to knowability; a large collection of changing items would still yield only opinion. - **B:** Correct: timelessness and spacelessness make a Form incapable of being otherwise, and only what cannot be otherwise can be known in Plato's strict sense. - **C:** Incorrect: Forms are grasped by reason (*nous*), not by any sense; an "inner sense" reading collapses the very distinction the 2025 question tests. - **D:** Incorrect: degrees of slowness keep Forms inside time, whereas the claim is that they are outside it and therefore admit no comparative rate of change at all.

Examiner trap 4: "Eternal" is not the answer by itself. The examiner wants the inference — non-temporal and non-spatial, therefore incapable of being otherwise, therefore knowable — not a restatement of the adjective.

MCQ 5. What counts as substance for Plato

On Plato's view, true substance (*ousia*) is

- A. the concrete individual before us, since it alone is the ultimate subject of every predication
- B. the underlying matter, which persists unchanged through every change the individual undergoes
- C. the compound formed from an intelligible structure and a portion of the Receptacle
- D. the universal Form, with particulars possessing being only derivatively through participation

Answer: D.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: this is Aristotle's *Categories* answer, and stating it as Plato's erases the inversion on which every comparison question turns. - **B:** Incorrect: Plato has no doctrine of matter as substance; the nearest item, the Receptacle (*chōra*) of the *Timaeus*, is a difficult "third kind" and is expressly not straightforward Aristotelian matter. - **C:** Incorrect: it fuses a *Timaeus* cosmological notion with a hylomorphic analysis that belongs to Aristotle, producing a doctrine neither philosopher holds. - **D:** Correct: for Plato the universal is the truly real (*ontōs on*) and the particular is a derivative copy, which is the exact reverse of Aristotle's primary substance.

Examiner trap 5: Do not soften this into "both thought universals and particulars are real". The marks lie in naming the inversion sharply and then showing what it costs each thinker.

MCQ 6. The Divided Line

In the Divided Line of *Republic* VI 509d–511e, the ascending order of states of mind and their objects is

- A. *pistis* — images; *eikasia* — visible things; *noēsis* — mathematical objects; *dianoia* — Forms
- B. *eikasia* — visible things; *pistis* — images; *dianoia* — Forms; *noēsis* — mathematical objects
- C. *dianoia* — images; *noēsis* — visible things; *eikasia* — mathematical objects; *pistis* — Forms
- D. *eikasia* — images; *pistis* — visible things; *dianoia* — mathematical objects; *noēsis* — Forms

Answer: D.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: it inverts the two lower states and inverts the two higher ones, destroying the correspondence between degree of clarity and degree of being. - **B:** Incorrect: shadows and reflections belong to conjecture (*eikasia*), not to belief (*pistis*), and dialectic terminates in Forms rather than in mathematical. - **C:** Incorrect: it assigns the two intellectual states to the visible section, which contradicts the primary cut of the line. - **D:** Correct: conjecture takes images, belief takes visible originals, thought takes mathematical objects and intellection takes the Forms culminating in the Good.

Examiner trap 6: The line is one scale read twice — clarity in the knower matched to being in the known. Reproducing the four names without that correspondence answers only half the question.

MCQ 7. What separates *dianoia* from *noēsi*

The decisive difference between thought (*dianoia*) and intellection (*noēsis*) in the Divided Line lies in

- A. the relative difficulty of the subject matter, geometry being distinctly easier than dialectic
- B. the direction of argument and the use of images, mathematics reasoning downward from hypotheses
- C. the number of premises each one employs, dialectic requiring more steps than geometrical demonstration
- D. the fact that only intellection is exercised by philosophers, since mathematics belongs to artisans

Answer: B.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: difficulty is a psychological accident; Plato's criterion is methodological, which is why the distinction survives even for an easy piece of dialectic. - **B:** Correct: mathematics takes the odd and the even and the figures "as known" and gives no account of them, while dialectic treats hypotheses as steps up to an unhypothetical principle (*archē anhypothetos*) and descends through Forms alone. - **C:** Incorrect: length of proof is not a criterion anywhere in the passage and would make the classification vary with the theorem chosen. - **D:** Incorrect: the distinction concerns methods, not professions; the mathematician's method remains *dianoia* however philosophical the practitioner.

Examiner trap 7: This is the single most examinable point in the Line. An answer that names the four segments but cannot say *why* mathematics falls short has given a description where an analysis was demanded.

MCQ 8. What the Cave adds to the Line

Consider the following statements about the Allegory of the Cave, *Republic* VII 514a–517a.

1. The ascent is described as painful and compelled, and education is presented as turning an organ of vision the soul already possesses.
2. The philosopher must descend again into the cave, will see badly in the dark and may be met with ridicule or violence.
3. The allegory replaces the epistemological scheme of the Line with an independent political doctrine.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 only
- B. 2 and 3 only
- C. 1 and 2 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: C.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: it drops the return (*katabasis*), which is the feature that converts the allegory into an argument about who should rule. - **B:** Incorrect: statement 3 is false, so any combination containing it fails; Plato himself insists at 517a–b that the image "must be applied as a whole" to what preceded. - **C:** Correct: compulsion and conversion (*periagōgē*), together with the descent and its transparent allusion to Socrates, are exactly what the Line does not contain. - **D:** Incorrect: the Cave extends the Line into education and politics; it does not displace the epistemology it narrates.

Examiner trap 8: Retelling the story is the classic way to lose a ten-mark answer. Map the four stages onto the four segments, then add compulsion and the return, and the narrative becomes an argument.

MCQ 9. The Sun analogy

In the Sun analogy of *Republic* VI 507a–509c, the Form of the Good stands to the intelligible order as the sun stands to the visible order because the Good

- A. illuminates the Forms for the mind without contributing anything at all to what they are
- B. confers on the Forms both their knowability and their being, and lies itself beyond being
- C. is the efficient craftsman who fashions the Forms out of some pre-existing material stuff
- D. is simply the highest member of the class of Forms, differing from all the rest only in rank

Answer: B.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: the analogy is deliberately double — as the sun gives visibility *and* generation, the Good gives knowability *and* being. - **B:** Correct: this reproduces both limbs of the analogy and Plato's most audacious phrase, that the Good is "beyond being" (*epekeina tēs ousias*) at 509b. - **C:** Incorrect: the craftsman is the Demiurge of the *Timaeus*, a different dialogue with a different explanatory role, and he does not create the Forms. - **D:** Incorrect: mere seniority would not explain why the other Forms depend on it for being, nor would it license the "beyond being" formula.

Examiner trap 9: Equating the Form of the Good with the Demiurge, or with a personal creator, is a standing error. Keep the *Republic's* principle and the *Timaeus's* craftsman apart and say why.

MCQ 10. The participation dilemma

The dilemma about participation raised at *Parmenides* 131a–c presses the question whether

- A. the whole Form or only a part of it is present in each participant, neither answer being coherent
- B. Forms exist at all, given that nobody has ever perceived a single one of them by sight or touch
- C. participation is really a relation between two Forms rather than between a Form and a particular
- D. the Form of the Good participates in the lesser Forms in the way that particulars participate in Forms

Answer: A.

Option explanations: - **A:** Correct: both horns are stated in the text, and together they show that "sharing in" has not yet been given a coherent analysis. - **B:** Incorrect: imperceptibility is a premise Plato accepts happily, not an objection; the dilemma is internal to the theory rather than empiricist. - **C:** Incorrect: relations among the highest kinds belong to the *Sophist's* later refinement, not to the participation dilemma. - **D:** Incorrect: the Good's relation to the other Forms is a question about grounding, and it is not the whole-or-part problem raised here.

Examiner trap 10: Plato states this objection against himself. Presenting the *Parmenides* difficulties as Aristotle's discoveries misreports the source and wastes the strongest evidence of Plato's philosophical honesty.

MCQ 11. The presuppositions of the Third Man

The regress known as the Third Man requires which pair of assumptions?

- A. That Forms are causally inert, and that sensible particulars are altogether unreal things
- B. That knowledge is recollection, and that the soul pre-exists the body it later occupies
- C. That the Form of F is itself F, and that the explaining Form differs from what it explains
- D. That every predicate has its own Form, and that the sensible world is in a ceaseless flux

Answer: C.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: causal inertness is a separate Aristotelian objection, and the regress does not need particulars to be unreal — only to resemble the Form. - **B:** Incorrect: recollection is an argument for Forms, not a premise of the regress against them. - **C:** Correct: self-predication plus non-identity generate the further Form at each stage, which is why denying self-predication is the standard Platonic escape route. - **D:** Incorrect: the scope of Forms and the flux of sensibles are background theses; neither of them, alone or together, yields a regress.

Examiner trap 11: Name the two premises. An answer that merely says "an infinite regress of Forms follows" cannot show where the argument may be blocked, and blocking it is what a critical evaluation requires.

MCQ 12. Plato's wider causal resources

Which statement most accurately describes Plato's explanatory apparatus once the *Timaeus* is taken into account?

- A. Forms give formal explanation, the Good grounds being and intelligibility, and the Demiurge orders becoming after the Forms
- B. The Form of the Good and the Demiurge are two names for one creator who produces the Forms and the sensible world alike
- C. The Receptacle (*chōra*) is Plato's term for matter and functions exactly as Aristotle's *hylē* does in hylomorphic analysis
- D. Plato offers only one kind of cause, so Aristotle's charge that he cannot explain motion applies without any qualification

Answer: A.

Option explanations: - **A:** Correct: it keeps three explanatory roles distinct and states the Demiurge's limits, which is the qualification the examiner rewards. - **B:** Incorrect: identifying the Good with the Demiurge collapses a *Republic* principle into a *Timaeus* craftsman and is interpretively contested at best. - **C:** Incorrect: the Receptacle is a difficult third kind in which becoming appears, and it is not straightforwardly identical with Aristotelian matter. - **D:** Incorrect: Plato has more than one explanatory resource; Aristotle's sharper charge is that *separated Forms themselves* do not explain motion or internal organisation.

Examiner trap 12: State Aristotle's objection in its accurate form. "Plato has no causes" is false and easily rebutted; "separated Forms cannot cause" is true and cannot be rebutted.

MCQ 13. Aristotle's critique of separated Forms

Which of the following states the "duplication" objection of *Metaphysics* I.9 correctly?

- A. Forms cannot be defined at all, because definition requires a genus and a differentia that Forms lack
- B. Forms are wholly unknowable, because knowledge proceeds only from the sense-perception of particulars

- C. Separated Forms double the entities requiring explanation, leaving two sets where there was one
- D. Forms are impossible, because nothing whatever can exist that is not located in space and in time

Answer: C.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: this is a difficulty about definability that Aristotle raises elsewhere, and it is not the parsimony charge the question names. - **B:** Incorrect: Aristotle holds that knowledge begins from sense and reaches universals, which is a positive epistemology rather than the duplication objection. - **C:** Correct: Stace summarises the charge with Aristotle's own barb that the Ideas are "nothing but eternalized things of nature", so the explanatory debt is merely transferred. - **D:** Incorrect: Aristotle nowhere argues that only spatio-temporal things exist — his own Unmoved Mover is immaterial.

Examiner trap 13: Keep Aristotle's five objections distinct: the Third Man regress, duplication, participation as metaphor, causal impotence and the absence of any account of generation. A merged blur earns one mark where five separated arguments earn several.

MCQ 14. Aristotle's repair of the theory of Forms

Aristotle's response to Plato is best described as

- A. rejecting form and universality altogether in favour of a strict materialism of atoms and void
- B. retaining Plato's separated Forms while adding efficient causation so as to make them effective
- C. accepting the Forms for mathematical objects while denying them for natural substances
- D. retaining intelligible form but making it immanent in the composite rather than separate

Answer: D.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: Aristotle keeps form as the central explanatory principle, and atomism is the rival position he argues against. - **B:** Incorrect: separation is precisely what he removes; adding an efficient cause to a separated Form would leave the regress and duplication charges untouched. - **C:** Incorrect: he denies separate existence to mathematical objects too, and reports Plato's "intermediates" as a doctrine he does not share. - **D:** Correct: the same word *eidos* is retained with a changed ontological status, which is the hinge of the 2024 comparison question.

Examiner trap 14: "Aristotle rejected the Forms" is a half-truth that reads as an error. He rejects their *separate existence* and their priority over individuals, and that precision is worth marks.

MCQ 15. Substance in the *Categorie*

In the *Categorie* (2a11 ff.), primary and secondary substance are related as follows.

- A. Primary substance is the species and secondary substance is the individual, since the species is more knowable
- B. Primary substance is the essence and secondary substance is the matter, since the essence explains the matter

- C. Primary substance is the concrete individual, and species and genus are secondary substances said of it
- D. Primary substance is the genus and secondary substance is the accident, since accidents inhere in genera

Answer: C.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: it reverses Aristotle's order and thereby reinstates the Platonic priority of the universal that the *Categories* is designed to overturn. - **B:** Incorrect: essence and matter are the vocabulary of the *Metaphysics*, not the predication-based scheme of the *Categories*. - **C:** Correct: "this man" and "this horse" (*tode ti*) are the ultimate subjects of predication, and everything else is said of them or is in them. - **D:** Incorrect: accidents are not substances at all in this scheme, and the genus is the more remote of the two secondary substances.

Examiner trap 15: The *Categories* answers "which things are substances?" by a logical criterion of subjecthood. Importing the *Metaphysics* answer here, or vice versa, is the commonest structural error in substance questions.

MCQ 16. The four candidates for substance in *Metaphysics* Z.3

Aristotle reviews substratum, essence, universal and genus as candidates for substance. His adjudication is that

- A. essence is accepted, the universal and the genus are rejected, and bare matter is neither a "this" nor separable
- B. the substratum taken as matter is accepted, because stripping away predicates leaves the one thing that truly underlies
- C. the genus is accepted, because it is the widest term under which the thing in question may be classified
- D. the universal is accepted, since Aristotle agrees with Plato that only what is common to many can explain

Answer: A.

Option explanations: - **A:** Correct: Z.3 rejects bare matter as a candidate, Z.4–6 and Z.17 install essence (*to ti ēn einai*), and Z.13 rules out the universal while the genus falls as predicated of many. - **B:** Incorrect: it accepts exactly the candidate Z.3 eliminates, since what remains after every predicate is removed is neither determinate nor separable. - **C:** Incorrect: a genus is predicated of many and therefore fails the same test that disqualifies the universal. - **D:** Incorrect: Aristotle's agreement with Plato ends precisely here; Z.13 states that no universal is a substance.

Examiner trap 16: Reproduce the list with the verdicts attached. A candidate who names the four candidates without saying which are rejected and why has described a procedure instead of using it.

MCQ 17. The *Categories*/*Metaphysics* question

The safest way to handle the apparent conflict between the *Categories* and *Metaphysics* Z is to argue that

- A. the *Metaphysics* silently withdraws the *Categories*, so only the later of the two doctrines should be reported
- B. the two works are simply inconsistent and Aristotle himself never noticed the problem at all
- C. the two works answer different questions — which things are substances, and what the substance *of* a thing is
- D. "substance" is used equivocally in the two works, with no philosophical connection at all between the senses

Answer: C.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: the developmental reading is available but rests on a disputed chronology, so it cannot be offered as the safe primary line. - **B:** Incorrect: Z.17 shows Aristotle reformulating the question deliberately, which is evidence of design rather than oversight. - **C:** Correct: the individual remains what exists in the primary way, while its form accounts for its being the individual it is — and Aristotle insists that being is said in many ways. - **D:** Incorrect: bare equivocation severs the link, whereas Z.17's question "why is this matter a house?" shows the second sense explaining the first.

Examiner trap 17: Name at least two readings. Mentioning only the different-questions solution loses the credit available for the developmental, individual-form and species-form alternatives, each of which should be flagged as contested.

MCQ 18. The ten categories

The ten categories of the *Categories* are best described as

- A. fundamental modes of predication and of being, only substance being a subject primarily
- B. ten physical components which jointly compose every material object that we encounter in nature
- C. ten successive stages through which every natural substance passes as it develops to maturity
- D. ten distinct kinds of cause, of which the final cause is much the most important of all

Answer: A.

Option explanations: - **A:** Correct: substance, quantity, quality, relation, place, time, position, state, action and being affected classify ways of being said, and the nine non-substantial categories are in or said of substances. - **B:** Incorrect: treating them as parts inside a thing is a category mistake in the literal sense; "yesterday" and "taller than Simmias" are not ingredients. - **C:** Incorrect: developmental stages belong to the analysis of change through potentiality and actuality, not to the classification of predicates. - **D:** Incorrect: the causes are four and belong to *Physics* II.3 and *Metaphysics* V, a different doctrine entirely.

Examiner trap 18: Substance *is*; accidents *belong to* substance. Fix that asymmetry first, and the difference between alteration and generation follows without further argument.

MCQ 19. Matter and form in hylomorphic analysis

Which statement about matter (*hylē*) and form (*morphē*) is correct?

- A. Matter and form are two independently existing objects that a craftsman joins mechanically together
- B. Matter is always the same featureless stuff, so bronze and wood differ only in the forms imposed on them
- C. Form is a separately existing paradigm that the matter of each substance imitates at a distance
- D. Matter is relative, since bronze is matter for the statue yet is itself formed from copper and tin

Answer: D.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: they are principles of analysis, not parts in a box; if they were separable objects the unity of the composite would be lost. - **B:** Incorrect: it confuses proximate matter, which is always already determinate, with the limiting notion of prime matter. - **C:** Incorrect: that is the Platonic paradigm relation, which Aristotle's immanent form is designed to replace. - **D:** Correct: relativity of matter and correlativity of the pair are the two features that let one scheme cover artefacts, organisms, change and definition.

Examiner trap 19: The 2025 statement "everything in the empirical world is a compound of Matter and Form" must be evaluated, not merely endorsed. It holds of sensible substances; accidents taken apart, mathematical abstractions and the immaterial Unmoved Mover are not further compounds in the same sense.

MCQ 20. Prime matter

The doctrine of prime matter (*prōtē hylē*) is best presented in an answer as

- A. a limiting posit of matter considered without determinate form and never existing independently
- B. an observable featureless stuff that chemists have since identified with the elementary particles
- C. a synonym for the Receptacle of Plato's *Timaeus*, which Aristotle adopted without any change
- D. the substantial form that is shared by all material things whatever their species may be

Answer: A.

Option explanations: - **A:** Correct: it is required to explain radical generation but is never actual on its own, and how far Aristotle commits to a single featureless prime matter is contested. - **B:** Incorrect: presenting a limit concept as an observed stuff is exactly the error that invites the charge of unintelligibility. - **C:** Incorrect: the Receptacle is Plato's difficult third kind and is not straightforwardly Aristotelian matter. - **D:** Incorrect: it inverts the definition, since prime matter is characterised by the absence of determinate form rather than by possessing a universal one.

Examiner trap 20: Concede the objection and then answer it. "Prime matter is unintelligible" is a real criticism; the reply is that it is a limit concept demanded by substantial generation, not a candidate for observation.

MCQ 21. The four causes

Which statement about the four causes (*aitiai*) is correct?

- A. They are four successive events, so the material cause acts first and the final cause acts last
- B. They are four competing hypotheses, of which the investigator must select the single true one
- C. They are four agents that act upon a thing from outside and may be observed quite separately
- D. They are four answers to "why?" about one thing, and in nature three of them typically coincide

Answer: D.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: the four can be simultaneous, and Stace notes that in every case of production all four operate together rather than in sequence. - **B:** Incorrect: they are complementary rather than rival; a complete explanation gives all four. - **C:** Incorrect: the material and formal causes are internal principles, and only the efficient cause is typically an external agent. - **D:** Correct: the form of the oak is what the acorn is for and what directs its development, which is why Aristotelian teleology is internal rather than designed.

Examiner trap 21: Use one worked example — the statue or the house — through all four causes. Four definitions attached to four different examples reads as a glossary, not as an explanation.

MCQ 22. Change, privation and the two kinds of change

Consider the following statements about Aristotle's analysis of change.

1. Coming-to-be is analysed through an underlying subject, an acquired form and the prior privation (*sterēsis*) of that form.
2. In accidental change the substantial form persists while a quantity, quality, place or other accident alters.
3. In substantial generation the prior substantial form persists as the identity of the new substance.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 and 2 only
- B. 2 and 3 only
- C. 1 and 3 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: A.

Option explanations: - **A:** Correct: the unmusical man becoming musical illustrates subject, form and privation, and accidental change is precisely the case in which the substance survives. - **B:** Incorrect: statement 3 is false, because in substantial generation an underlying material potential acquires a *new* substantial form. - **C:** Incorrect: it retains the same false claim about substantial change while dropping the correct account of accidental change. - **D:** Incorrect: accepting 3 would make generation indistinguishable from alteration and would leave destruction unexplained.

Examiner trap 22: Reserve "the form persists" for accidental change. Saying it of substantial generation contradicts the doctrine and undermines any answer on developmental change in substance.

MCQ 23. Potentiality and actuality

Aristotle's definition of change at *Physics* III.1 (201a10) is best rendered as

- A. the actuality of the potential as potential, a passage from potential to actual being
- B. the replacement of one actual thing by another actual thing that is numerically different
- C. the movement of matter through space under the action of some external moving agency
- D. the appearance of a wholly new being out of absolute non-being at each successive moment

Answer: A.

Option explanations: - **A:** Correct: the qualification "as potential" is what makes the formula describe the process rather than its completed result. - **B:** Incorrect: replacement without an underlying potential reintroduces the Parmenidean problem that the doctrine is designed to solve. - **C:** Incorrect: locomotion is only one species of change; Aristotle's *kinēsis* also covers alteration, growth and generation. - **D:** Incorrect: creation from absolute non-being is exactly what Aristotle denies, since nothing comes from nothing.

Examiner trap 23: Do not drop the phrase "as potential". Without it the definition collapses into the description of a finished actuality and answers nothing about becoming.

MCQ 24. The priority of actuality

Aristotle argues that actuality (*energeia*) is prior to potentiality (*dynamis*) in which respects?

- A. In spatial position, in numerical count and in bare perceptibility to the senses
- B. In causal power, in metaphysical dignity and in popularity among his later successors
- C. In explanatory efficiency, in theoretical economy and in the overall simplicity of statement
- D. In definition, in time at the species level, and in substance as the end of the process

Answer: D.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: none of these is a mode of priority Aristotle recognises, and Forms and actualities are not spatially ordered at all. - **B:** Incorrect: dignity and reception are rhetorical rather than metaphysical grounds and prove nothing about the relation of the two notions. - **C:** Incorrect:

methodological virtues are not the argument; the argument concerns definition, generation and end. - **D:** Correct: to define "potentially F" you must already grasp actual F; only an actual oak produces acorns; and the end is what the process is for.

Examiner trap 24: Priority is explanatory, definitional and teleological — not temporal in every sense. An individual potential state can precede its own actualisation in time, and conceding that openly strengthens the answer.

MCQ 25. Remedial drill — what Plato says about the physical world

A candidate writes that Plato "denies the reality of the physical world". The correct correction is that Plato

- A. holds the sensible world to be a systematic illusion projected by ignorance, much as Advaita treats *māyā*
- B. grants sensible particulars a real but derivative being as copies of Forms, hence objects of opinion
- C. treats the physical world as fully real and equal in status to the Forms, differing only in accessibility
- D. leaves the ontological status of the physical world entirely undetermined throughout the dialogues

Answer: B.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: illusionism is precisely the position Plato does not hold; a copy is a defective instance of what it copies, not a non-entity. - **B:** Correct: derivative reality is the accurate formula, and it explains why sensibles yield belief (*pistis*) rather than nothing at all. - **C:** Incorrect: equal status would destroy the argument that different faculties must have different objects, argued at *Republic* V 476e–480a. - **D:** Incorrect: the two-level scheme assigns the sensible world a definite subordinate status, so indeterminacy is not the reading.

Examiner trap 25: Comparisons with Advaita's *māyā* are legitimate only when the difference is stated. Plato degrades the sensible world's rank; he does not deny that it is there.

MCQ 26. Remedial drill — what Aristotle denies about universals

Which correction of the claim that "Aristotle denies universals" is accurate?

- A. He denies universals in logic but retains them in physics, where species-terms are indispensable
- B. He accepts universals as separately existing entities but denies that they can ever be known
- C. He accepts universals only as names, holding that nothing in reality corresponds to a general term
- D. He retains species and genus as secondary substances, denying only their separate existence

Answer: D.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: the same account of universals runs through both, since predication in the *Categories* is not restricted by subject matter. - **B:** Incorrect: separate existence is what he rejects, and universals are for him precisely what science knows. - **C:** Incorrect: nominalism is a later medieval position; Aristotle grounds the universal in the immanent form of the individual. - **D:** Correct: "man" and "animal" remain secondary substances, less real than *this* man, which is the exact and defensible formulation.

Examiner trap 26: Precision here converts a wrong answer into a strong one. Write "he rejects *separated* Forms", never "he rejects forms", and the entire comparison keeps its balance.

MCQ 27. Remedial drill — what potentiality is not

The claim that "potentiality is indefinable", tested in 2021, is best explained by saying that potentiality

- A. is a statistical likelihood that a given outcome will occur, measurable in principle by frequency
- B. cannot be defined independently of actuality, since "potentially a table" presupposes an actual table
- C. is undefinable because Aristotle nowhere discusses it, leaving only later commentators to supply an account
- D. is a hidden quality inside matter that can be detected once the matter is sufficiently divided

Answer: B.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: *dynamis* is an ontological capacity of a determinate material, not a probability; wood is potentially a table whatever the frequency of carpentry. - **B:** Correct: this is why actuality is conceptually prior even where the potential state precedes in the individual's own time. - **C:** Incorrect: *Metaphysics* IX (Θ) is devoted to the pair, so silence is not the ground of indefinability. - **D:** Incorrect: division reveals more matter, never a capacity; the capacity is intelligible only through the actuality it is a capacity for.

Examiner trap 27: The wooden-table example must run through all three stages — block of wood, the carpenter's working, the finished table — and must be labelled *dynamis*, *kinēsis* and *energeia/entelecheia*. A bare example without the vocabulary is half an answer.

MCQ 28. Remedial drill — how the Unmoved Mover moves

The Unmoved Mover of *Metaphysics* XII (Λ).7 moves the cosmos

- A. by efficient causation, imparting motion to the outermost sphere by direct physical contact with it
- B. by creating the world out of nothing at a first moment of time, before which nothing existed
- C. as a final cause, being the object of desire and thought — it "moves as the beloved moves the lover"
- D. by continuously sustaining matter in existence, acting as a conserving cause at every instant

Answer: C.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: pushing would make the mover itself moved and would reintroduce the potentiality that pure actuality excludes. - **B:** Incorrect: creation from nothing at a first moment is a later theological doctrine; Aristotle's cosmos and its motion are eternal. - **C:** Correct: attraction rather than propulsion is the whole point, and it is why the mover can be immaterial, changeless and thought thinking itself (*noēsis noēseōs*). - **D:** Incorrect: conservation belongs to the scholastic development of the doctrine, not to Aristotle's own argument.

Examiner trap 28: Do not assimilate the Unmoved Mover to a personal creator. It completes the actuality–potentiality system as the ultimate explanatory terminus, and saying so keeps the answer inside the printed clause.

MCQ 29. Remedial drill — the four causes as explanation, not narrative

A script states: "First the material cause supplies wood, then the efficient cause acts, then the formal cause appears, and finally the final cause is reached." The error is that

- A. the order given is right but the labels have been interchanged between the formal and final causes
- B. the four are aspects of one explanation and may be simultaneous rather than successive events
- C. there are five causes on Aristotle's mature view, and the list omits the instrumental cause
- D. only the efficient cause is a genuine cause, the other three being metaphors for it

Answer: B.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: relabelling leaves the deeper mistake untouched, which is the conversion of an explanatory scheme into a chronology. - **B:** Correct: Aristotelian causation includes what we would call reasons as well as causes, and all four operate together in any case of production. - **C:** Incorrect: the causes are four, and the instrumental factor is an aspect of efficient causation rather than a fifth kind. - **D:** Incorrect: reducing the four to the efficient cause is the modern narrowing that Aristotle's scheme is designed to resist.

Examiner trap 29: The word "cause" is wider in Aristotle than in modern usage. Say so in one clause, and the four-cause doctrine stops looking like bad physics and starts looking like a theory of explanation.

MCQ 30. Remedial drill — formal cause and Platonic Form

The relation between Aristotle's formal cause and Plato's Form is that

- A. they are the same entity described in two vocabularies, so the dispute between the two philosophers is merely verbal
- B. both are called *eidos*, but Aristotle's is immanent in *this* composite and Plato's is separate
- C. the formal cause is a mental concept, whereas the Platonic Form is an object outside the mind
- D. Aristotle abandoned the word *eidos* precisely in order to mark his break with his teacher

Answer: B.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: separation versus immanence changes what the entity can do, so the dispute is substantive rather than terminological. - **B:** Correct: the shared word with a changed ontological status is exactly what makes this the favourite trap in comparison questions. - **C:** Incorrect: making the formal cause mental is conceptualism, which neither philosopher accepts. - **D:** Incorrect: he retains the word deliberately, which is why the distinction must be drawn by ontological status rather than by vocabulary.

Examiner trap 30: In the 2024 comparison, run one axis — separated paradigm versus immanent essence — and then derive the consequences for causation, generation, universals and substance. Two parallel summaries score poorly.

MCQ 31. Remedial drill — the standing of the "mathematicals"

The doctrine that Plato posited mathematical objects as intermediates (*ta metaxu*) between Forms and sensibles should be reported as

- A. a doctrine stated explicitly in the *Republic* alongside the account of the Divided Line
- B. a modern scholarly conjecture with no ancient textual or doxographical support whatever
- C. Aristotle's testimony at *Metaphysics* I.6 (987b14), not a doctrine stated in the dialogues
- D. a Neoplatonic addition of the third century which later editors inserted into the Platonic text

Answer: C.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: the Line assigns mathematical objects to thought (*dianoia*) but never states a separate order of intermediate entities. - **B:** Incorrect: the report is ancient and is Aristotle's own, so calling it a modern conjecture misstates the evidence. - **C:** Correct: the safe formula is "on Aristotle's testimony", which shows source discipline and protects the claim from challenge. - **D:** Incorrect: there is no textual-interpolation story here, and inventing one would be a fabricated evidential claim.

Examiner trap 31: Attribute reports to their reporters. The name "Third Man" likewise comes from Aristotle at *Metaphysics* 990b17 and 1039a2; the argument itself is Plato's at *Parmenides* 132a–b.

MCQ 32. Remedial drill — citation and verdict discipline

Which answer-writing practice is defensible in this topic?

- A. Quoting long passages of Jowett's translation from memory to establish the exact wording of a Platonic argument
- B. Citing "Plato, *Republic*, Chapter 7, page 214" so that the examiner can locate the passage in a particular printed edition
- C. Ending a comparison with a balanced description of both thinkers and no ruling, since UPSC penalises taking sides

D. Citing Plato by Stephanus pagination and Aristotle by Bekker numbers, and closing with a graded verdict

Answer: D.

Option explanations: - **A:** Incorrect: translations differ markedly, so a remembered wording is the least reliable evidence available; prefer the reference to the quotation. - **B:** Incorrect: chapter and page numbers vary between editions, whereas Stephanus and Bekker references are edition-invariant. - **C:** Incorrect: a directive such as "critically discuss" or "evaluate" obliges a ruling; balanced description without a verdict answers the topic instead of the question. - **D:** Correct: edition-invariant citation plus a reasoned verdict is the combination that signals textual control and analytical nerve together.

Examiner trap 32: A verdict must follow from the body and must be graded rather than absolute — for example, that Aristotle's immanent form solves Plato's causal problem while inheriting his problem about universals.